subconscious, the symmetry of the image is strangely appropriate, since it captures the nature of the team.

We were moving parts in a highly efficient machine. Our ruthlessness and resourcefulness were innate. We were operating the 2 per cent rule, continually seeking subtle ways to gain marginal advantage, especially away from home, where we struggled when the ball wasn't moving around. That attention to detail extended to Mushtaq Ahmed, our spin-bowling coach until 2014, teaching us the reverse swing.

He had done so, with Matty Prior, at Sussex. My job, as the principal shiner of the ball, was to monitor the moisture on the rough side. Matty would throw it directly to me, rather than going through the hands of the fielders, because their sweat could dampen the dry side. It is amazing, if you don't touch the dry side for two or three overs, how rough it will get, even when it is thirty or forty overs old on hard ground.

Fielders consciously threw it seam up to me, so I could catch it on the shiny side. There were unavoidable complications – sometimes someone with sweaty hands would make a diving stop or roll on the ball – but as soon as the ball is moving sideways on a good wicket you are back in the game.

Another trick to accelerate the process is skidding the ball in from the outfield on a lower trajectory so that its rougher side hits the ground. Footmarks left on previous wickets are a favourite target. If the ball is reversing, though, you never throw it on the ground. For instance, if it is hit to the boundary the fielder carries it forward until he is sure of the return throw reaching mid-off on the full.

This also helped mentally, through the placebo effect of knowing we had done everything to look after the ball. So much of sport is played in the mind; reaching the finite goal of being number one, faster than we expected, was dangerous. Andy Flower spoke of setting mini-targets, reinforcing and renewing habits. He was the main driver of cultural change and continued to talk of a higher calling than the fleeting sensation of victory, but such all-encompassing ambition was not easy to sustain.

That big-picture policy had already included an evolution of authority. I had been appointed one-day captain in May 2011. Stuart Broad simultaneously assumed leadership of the T20 team, leaving Straussy clear to concentrate on the Test group. The setting for my introductory speech,